



KITASATO SHIBASABURŌ

Japanese doctor and bacteriologist
1853–1931



Kitasato developed the diphtheria antitoxin using blood from horses that were immune to the disease—which means their bodies could fight it off.

As a young scientist, Kitasato Shibasaburō traveled to Berlin, Germany, to study science. He worked with the famous microbiologist Robert Koch. He examined the bacteria that caused tetanus and diphtheria and discovered that it wasn't the microbes themselves that caused the symptoms, but the toxins they released.

With his newfound knowledge, Kitasato was able to develop antitoxins to fight the toxins and treat the illnesses. He returned to his home country of Japan in 1892 to put his learning into practice.



In 1894, the Japanese government sent Kitasato to Hong Kong to investigate an outbreak of bubonic plague. He took six assistants and a portable laboratory with him, ready to examine plague victims and solve the mystery of what caused this deadly disease. But three days later, a rival bacteriologist arrived!

Alexandre was the first to link bubonic plague to rats.